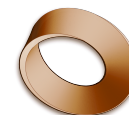


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Mr. Rawson • GCSE Physics

Kinematics L3: Constant Velocity

Constant velocity

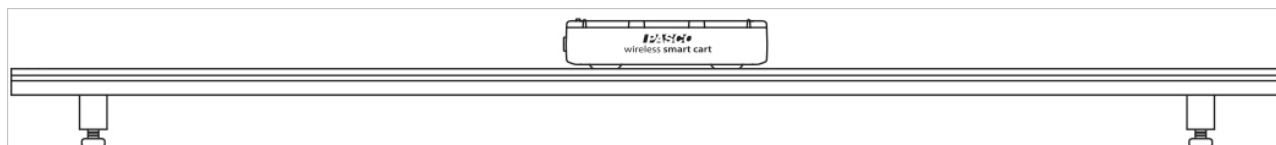
Velocity is displacement divided by the time taken:

$$\text{velocity} = \frac{\text{displacement}}{\text{time}}$$

Displacement is a vector — it carries a *direction* as well as a size. Divide a vector by a time and what you get is still a vector, so **velocity is a vector too**. That is exactly what separates velocity from speed: velocity also tells you *which way*.

So a cart moving at constant velocity is not only changing its position — it is changing position **in a particular direction**, at a steady rate. Today you record that same motion two ways at once, as a **position–time** graph and a **velocity–time** graph, and look for the pattern that connects them.

Set up



The track must be LEVEL — no books under either end. Equipment illustration courtesy of PASCO scientific.

1. Put the track flat on the bench. Adjust the feet until a cart placed in the middle **does not creep either way**. This matters — a sloping track will not give you constant velocity.
2. Press the cart's **ON** button. Check the Bluetooth light is **blinking red**.
3. On the laptop, connect the cart in SPARKvue and build a graph of **position** and a graph of **velocity**, both against time. (*See the SPARKvue guides if you are stuck.*)
4. Find the **+X arrow printed on top of the cart**. That arrow is the positive direction. Point it **away from you, down the track**, and leave it that way all lesson.

What you are looking for

Key concept

A **velocity–time graph** has **velocity on the *y*-axis** and **time along the *x*-axis**. So:

- **How far the line sits from zero on the *y*-axis** tells you *how fast*.
- **A line below zero on the *y*-axis** means it is going in the **negative direction**.
- **A line with a slope of zero does *not* mean it has stopped**. A slope of zero means the **velocity is not changing** — steady speed. Only a line sitting *on* zero means stopped.

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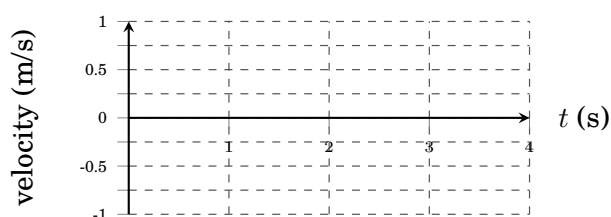
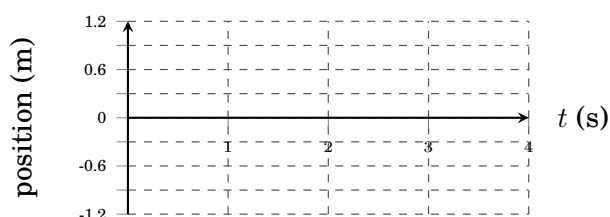
The four runs

Tick your prediction first, then run it, then sketch what the screen showed. Leave your prediction as it is — if it was wrong, that is the useful bit.

► **Where you start the cart changes from run to run.** Only run 1 begins in the middle. Read the start position at the top of each one — getting it wrong is what makes a graph come out the opposite way round to everybody else's. **Catch the cart at the far end every time.**

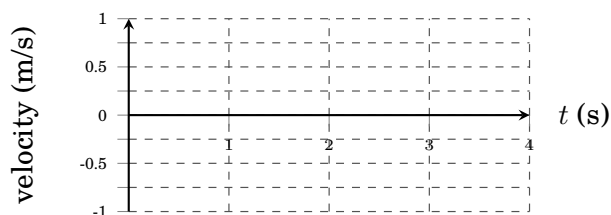
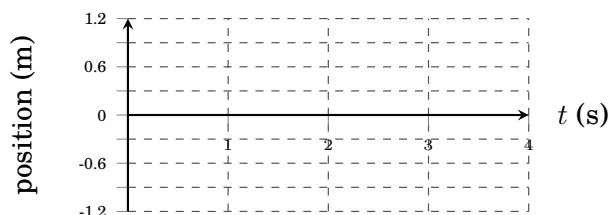
Run 1. Middle of the track. Cart sitting still, 4 seconds.

Predict the *velocity* line: ☐ on the zero line ☐ zero slope, above ☐ zero slope, below ☐ tilting up ☐ tilting down



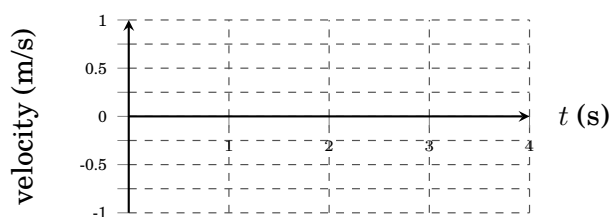
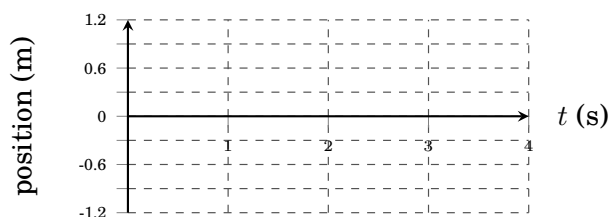
Run 2. Start at the near end. Gentle push in +X — away from you.

Predict the *velocity* line: ☐ on the zero line ☐ zero slope, above ☐ zero slope, below ☐ tilting up ☐ tilting down



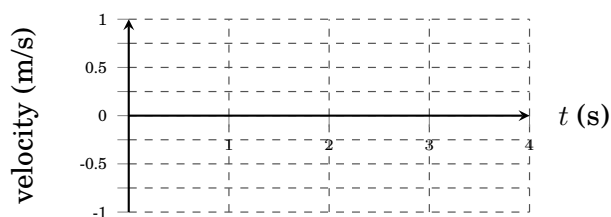
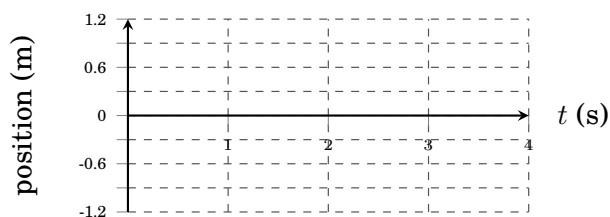
Run 3. Near end again. Harder push, same direction.

Predict the *velocity* line: ☐ on the zero line ☐ zero slope, above ☐ zero slope, below ☐ tilting up ☐ tilting down



Run 4. Carry the cart to the far end. Push it back towards you — -X.

Predict the *velocity* line: ☐ on the zero line ☐ zero slope, above ☐ zero slope, below ☐ tilting up ☐ tilting down



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Your results

You are going to get the cart's velocity out of the graphs **two different ways**, and they should agree.

Key concept

SPARKvue's  **Linear Fit** tool draws the best straight line through your data and gives you the equation of that line in the form

$$y = mx + b$$

where m is the **slope** and b is the **y -intercept** — the value of y where the line crosses the vertical axis.

- **On the position–time graph, m is the velocity.** Position divided by time is exactly what a velocity is, so the slope of that line *is* how fast the cart was going, with a sign telling you which way.
- **On the velocity–time graph, m should come out as zero** — the velocity is not changing — and then b **is the velocity**, because a line with a slope of zero sits at the same y value the whole way across.

Two routes, one answer. If your two numbers do not roughly match, one of the fits is wrong — most likely you have fitted the push or the catch as well as the steady part.

Highlight only the steady middle of the run before you fit. Leave out the push at the start and the catch at the end — neither is constant velocity, and both will drag your line off.

► Your velocity–time slope will almost never be exactly 0. Write down whatever it says, even if it is something like 0.00034. We will talk about what a number that small is telling you.

Run	The cart is...	Its velocity is...	Slope m of the position–time line / m s^{-1}	Slope m of the velocity–time line	Intercept b of the velocity–time line / m s^{-1}
1					
2					
3					
4					

Word banks — use one option from each bank for the two word columns.

Bank A — the cart is...	Bank B — its velocity is...
stationary • moving in the positive direction • moving in the negative direction	zero • constant and positive • constant and negative

What the shape means

1) **Compare** runs 2 and 3. What is different about the two velocity lines, and why?

2) **Explain** what is different about run 4's velocity line, and what that tells you. Say what its *position*–time line did as well.

3) **Explain** why a velocity–time line with a **slope of zero** does **not** mean the cart has stopped.
